
The First TV Adaptation of Lord of the Flies Is Here. It's Gripping, Heartbreaking—and Unexpected.

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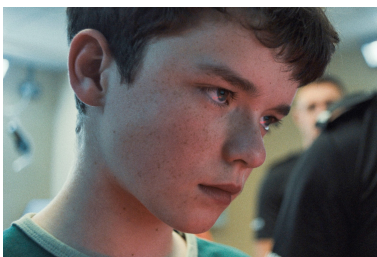
The First TV Adaptation of Lord of the Flies Is Here. It's Gripping, Heartbreaking—and Unexpected.

This article contains spoilers for Lord of the Flies.

You might expect Jack Thorne, best known in the United States for co-creating the hit limited series [Adolescence](#), about a schoolboy who is arrested on suspicion of killing a female classmate, to deliver a *Lord of the Flies* adaptation full of despair. William Golding's 1954 novel and Thorne's 2025 [Emmys juggernaut](#) share some grim themes: Apparently upstanding tween boys can break bad out of nowhere, and with disastrous consequences. Possibly, there is something in British culture or modern life that enables boys' worst instincts, but fixing that thing will be incredibly difficult. But, unexpectedly and happily, Thorne's gripping new series—on Netflix as of Monday after debuting on the BBC earlier this year—does something else with this seven-decade-old story: It pulls out the sense of humanity and heartbreak at its core.

Would a pack of British boys, between the ages of 6 and 12, stranded via plane crash on a tropical island, turn on one another, form factions, and kill the weak among them, in an orgy of carnivalesque violence? *Lord of the Flies*, which tells a story in which they do, was written in the aftermath of World War II, and since its publication it's been a useful point of reference for people who want to argue for the inherent darkness of the human heart. Counterarguments—*Lord of the Flies* was an indictment of Western culture, not of human nature; *Lord of the Flies* has to be read as a novel inspired by the horrors of one particular war, rather than as a timeless tale—can get little traction in the face of this brutal story. The historian Rutger Bregman [found the real tale of a group of six Tongan boys](#) who, half a century ago, survived for a year and a half on an island after a shipwreck, and did so in perfect harmony, and used that story to try to chip at the edifice of common-sense doomthink that *Lord of the Flies* is partially responsible for perpetuating. Human beings, Bregman argued, *want* to cooperate. But, compared to the seductive allure of dark-hearted savagery, this kind of narrative just doesn't have the juice. Nobody's writing [an Iron Maiden song](#) about *that*.

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In crafting this new miniseries, the first-ever TV adaptation of the novel, Thorne smartly finds a middle ground. He keeps the saddest parts of Golding's story, but personalizes everything, so that this becomes a story of particular people—a tragedy, but one that doesn't have to indict the whole human race. Thorne assigns one episode each to four central characters. Piggy (David McKenna) is the character most readers remember best, for his terrible death in Golding's novel, and he gets the first episode here. Piggy is a rational kid, a clear thinker, one of the few boys with the correct concerns (yes, the kids should be keeping track of where they poop!), but, as you could guess from his unkind nickname, he's got a pudgy body and wheedling affect that make him into a target. Next comes Jack (Lox Pratt, who will play Draco Malfoy in the upcoming *Harry Potter* television show—[Dramioniacs](#), get ready), a handsome, blue-eyed popular kid, leader of the boys' choir that becomes his island hunting crew, and a fascist in the making, with a deep scorn for weakness. ("I'm bored of worrying about being cruel," Jack says, in a line added to the new series, voicing the spirit of our dark decade. "Time to get [waxy](#).") Simon (Ike Talbut) is an unworldly, spiritual boy, originally in Jack's choir, who aligns himself with Piggy and Ralph and ends up paying for it dearly. Finally, Ralph (Winston Sawyers) is the reluctant elected leader, with the heart of a democrat. He's the sole boy who opposes Jack, up until they're rescued on the beach at the end of the series.

While the 1963 *Lord of the Flies* movie adaptation by Peter Brook stuck closely to the scant background information about these characters that you find in Golding's book, Thorne has added a lot. In this new series, Piggy's real name is Nicholas, and he likes Groucho Marx. Jack has a harsh and uncaring father, as does Simon, and they bond over this. We find out Jack and Simon developed a friendship at school over holidays when they were both left alone with the headmaster, à la [The Holdovers](#). Those days are chronicled in a diary Simon kept, which Jack finds and reads. There is some implication that Simon may have had a crush on Jack, as when he describes his "yellow hair shining like the sun itself," but the heart of their relationship is Jack's abandonment of Simon as soon as everyone else comes back from break—a classic drama of tweenagerhood that takes on a sinister cast, given what's happening on the island. And Ralph's mother has very recently died, as we see in flashbacks starring Rory Kinnear as Ralph's loving dad.

These are only four of about 50 kids on the island. Most of the other boys in Golding's novel are but sketches, most lacking names, a sparseness that adds to the feeling that we're dealing with a mob, seething and directionless, just mouths to eat and arms to hit. The anonymity of most of the boys is, in fact, the primary failure that the boys' eventual rescuer scolds Ralph for, in both book and show. There are so many pressing needs and fun distractions on the island that the group leaders don't carry out their initial plan to keep count of how many stranded kids they have, and so don't even know whether or not they've lost one, after disasters like the forest fire they start early on. "I would have thought a pack of British boys would have been able to put up a better show than that," this rescuer, a Navy officer, says, not knowing the half of it.

In one repeating and very effective visual motif in Thorne's new adaptation, the camera periodically dwells on the individual faces of the boys on the island, even those without speaking parts. This device reminds us how little we know about these bit players, and hammers home the heartbreaking vulnerability of all of them—especially the younger half of the group, kindergarten-age kids mostly discounted as useless and derided for wailing in fear every night. The series is generally great to look at, making the most of the novel's most memorable scenes, like Jack's tribe's first pig kill, with uncertain, spear-wielding boys encircling a sow in a green meadow, or the moment where the group sees a dead paratrooper's chute blooming in the wind like the frilled ruff of a giant lizard, and mistakes it for a monster.

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The most heartbreaking change Thorne makes is to alter the way Nicky/Piggy dies. In the book, Piggy and Ralph decide to approach Jack's tribe and try to get them to return Piggy's glasses, which can be used to ignite fires. Instead, one of Jack's boys dislodges a great boulder that knocks Piggy off the cliff and onto a rock below, killing him at once, while smashing the conch shell that represents order on the island. Thorne, instead, stages this sad event as an unfolding tragedy. The tribe and the duo meet on the beach. "Stop the boring Nickpig," Jack says, as Nicky tries to make his case for his spectacles' return, until Jack's most sadistic lieutenant, Roger (Thomas Connor), bashes Nicky over the head with a rock. Nicky and Ralph run into the undergrowth and, while they're hiding from the pursuing tribe, Nicky dies slowly, over the course of hours. This gives Ralph a chance to apologize for revealing his friend's cruel nickname to the other boys, giving them a verbal weapon to use against Piggy on their first day on the island. "You weren't to know," a fading Nicky comforts him, in a bit of Thorne-original dialogue. "What?" Ralph asks. "That you'd like me so much," Nicky says.

Purists may not like how much Thorne has added to this story, and how these additions dilute the sense of archetype that drove the story of Golding's novel. We see Jack is a bully, but he's also an uncertain and lonely kid. Simon is a mystic and an outcast, but also, maybe, a boy living in the closet. Ralph betrays Nicky, but in this adaptation, he gets one last chance to do everything he can to defend his friend. There is something in these backstories that softens the dark message of *Lord of the Flies*. These boys broke bad, the adaptation seems to say. But it doesn't mean we all will.

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